TRILLS AND THRILLS : BIRDWATCHING IN INDIA - SALIM ALI

COMPREHENSION : TEXTUAL PASSAGE

Read the excerpt from Birdwatching in India and answer the questions that follow

One of the standard questions to me is about the thrilling adventures in a lifetime of exploring for birds. My answer must seem disappointing. Ornithology as a hobby or profession, though full of adventures, rewards and disappointments, is usually one of the most peaceful of pursuits. It is certainly not lacking in excitement and thrills, though. With the richness and variety of bird life in India, exciting discoveries can be made by any birdwatcher. It is refreshing to find that birdwatching as a hobby is growing rapidly in popularity. I had grown up only on the traditional accounts of the nesting habits of birds. These were interesting enough for a keen bird photographer, as I was, to want to record on film.

But while concealed in a canvas hide, perched high up on a stepladder, a few yards away from the nests, I noticed some unusual goings on which clearly showed that the birds had not read the textbooks. While the field study of birds is a peaceful occupation, it is not entirely without hazards. In elephant-ridden jungles in South India for instance, I have frequently found myself in disturbing situations

1. According to the author, why might his answer about "thrilling adventures" be disappointing to some listeners?

2. What did the author discover while observing birds from his canvas hide?

3. 1. Based on the passage, which of the following are TRUE?

A. The author believes ornithology is mostly a peaceful pursuit.

B. Birdwatching is becoming less popular in India.

C. The richness of bird life in India allows for new discoveries.

D. The author has never experienced a "disturbing situation" while birdwatching.

Choose the correct option:

(a) Only A and C

(b) Only B and D

(c) Only A, B, and C

(d) All four statements

4. Which of the following statements regarding the author's observations are TRUE?

A. The author used a canvas hide and a stepladder for his field studies.

B. The birds always behaved exactly as the textbooks described.

C. The author was a keen bird photographer.

D. Wild animals like elephants can pose a hazard to birdwatchers.

Choose the correct option:

(a) Only B and C

(b) Only A, C, and D

(c) Only A and D

(d) All four statements

5.Pick out a word from the passage which means ‘examine or evaluate’

Read the excerpt from Birdwatching in India and answer the questions that follow

Ornithology may sometimes entail hazards of a different kind. I recall one particularly hair-raising incident along the Himalayan trail from Almora to the Lipu Lekh Pass on my way to Lake Manasarovar and Mount Kailas in 1945. It was at a particularly narrow part of the trail with a thousand feet of vertical scarp on one side and the roaring Kali river some 300 feet vertically down the other.

The porters pitched the tent there, though I had walked ahead of them. Just at that moment a tiny bird – how well I remember that Yellow-naped Yuhina! – got up to the top of a bush, some yards away on the flanking hillside.

DE KOLAM

Just as I got it in the field of my glasses, it hopped a bit further up. So, to get a better view I took a step back, with the glasses still glued to my eyes, entirely unmindful of where I was standing with my back to the abyss.

As I did so, I felt a small pebble slip from under my heel and heard a faint continuing clatter as it went rolling down the hill. Still unmindful of anything untoward, I casually looked back over my shoulder. What I saw literally made my hair stand on end. In a flash I realised that I was on the very edge of beyond two inches more and I would have followed that rollicking pebble.

1. Why did the author take a step back without looking behind him?

2. Which of the following details accurately describe the setting of the incident?

A. The incident occurred in 1945 on the way to Lake Manasarovar.

B. The trail was wide and easy for the porters to navigate.

C. There was a vertical scarp on one side and a river on the other.

D. The author was traveling along the Himalayan trail from Almora.

Choose the correct option:

(a) Only A, B, and C

(b) Only A, C, and D

(c) Only B and D

(d) All four statements

3. What were the immediate consequences of the author's "step back"?

4. Which of the following statements are TRUE according to the passage?

A. The author was fully aware of the danger behind him while watching the bird.

B. The Yellow-naped Yuhina is the bird that distracted the author.

C. The porters pitched the tent after the author had already walked ahead.

D. The author felt his hair "stand on end" because of the freezing Himalayan wind.

Choose the correct option:

(a) Only A and B

(b) Only B and C

(c) Only C and D

(d) All four statements

5.Pick out the word from the passage which means ‘not conscious or aware’

DE KOLAM

Answers

SET 1

1. Ornithology as a hobby or profession, though full of adventures, rewards and disappointments, is usually one of the most peaceful of pursuits

2.(d) (Option C is correct, and B and D are indeed incorrect)

3.(a) Only A and C

B is false (it's growing in popularity); D is false (he mentions hazards).

4.(b) Only A, C, and D

B is false (he says the birds "had not read the textbooks").

5.Explore

SET 2

1. B. He was focused on getting a better view of a Yellow-naped Yuhina through his binoculars.

2.(b) (B is incorrect; the trail was "particularly narrow")

3.(a) (A and D are incorrect based on the text)

4.(b) (A is false—he was "unmindful"; D is false—it was due to fear)

5.unmindful

DISCOURSES

DIARY

In the lesson "Trills and Thrills," Dr. Salim Ali describes a heart-pounding encounter with a wild tusker while birdwatching in the jungles of Parambikulam, while is accompanied by Baron Omar Rolf, who runs away without even seeing the elephant. Prepare the diary for Dr. Salim Ali

February 17, 1946

Tuesday

What a heart-stopping day! It began peacefully enough. I set out early with Baron Omar Rolf and a forest guard, trekking through tall grass to find the Broad-tailed Grass Warbler. The air was still, and the grass was so high it swallowed us up. Then, everything changed in a heartbeat.

As we rounded a bend, the guard suddenly ducked. My heart nearly stopped—a massive tusker was walking right toward us! I didn't wait a second; I turned and ran as fast as my legs could carry me, shouting for Omar to do the same. I have never seen anyone move so fast!

DE KOLAM

The Baron sprinted past me like a professional athlete, his long legs flying. When I finally caught up to him—hot, breathless, and shaking—he looked at me and whispered, "What was it?" He hadn't even seen the elephant! He just saw me running and took off.

Looking back, it’s quite funny. The poor elephant probably didn't even notice us; he just wandered off into the brush. But it was a sharp reminder: birdwatching may be a "peaceful" hobby, but in the wild, you must always be ready to move

NARRATIVE

During his birdwatching travels in 1946, Dr. Salim Ali along with his friend Baron Omar Rolf had a thrilling and funny encounter with a wild elephant at Parambikulam. Prepare a likely narrative

In February 1946, I was exploring the beautiful jungles of Parambikulam. My goal was to study the nesting habits of the Broad-tailed Grass Warbler. I was not alone; I was joined by an Austrian anthropologist named Baron Omar Rolf, who was very keen on birdwatching.

Guided by a forest guard, we were walking along a narrow animal trail. The grass was very thick and stood over five feet high. Suddenly, as we turned a bend, the guard ducked down in excitement and pointed ahead. My heart skipped a beat—a massive wild tusker was striding down the same path, coming directly toward us!

Knowing how dangerous a wild elephant can be at close range, I didn't waste a second. I turned and fled as fast as I could, motioning to the Baron to do the same. I have never seen anyone react so quickly! The Baron spun around with the agility of a cat and sprinted away on his long legs. He was so fast that he outdistanced me by a hundred yards in no time.

I finally caught up to him, hot and panting. The Baron looked at me and whispered breathlessly, "What was it?" I couldn't help but be amused. He had been running for his life without even seeing the elephant! As it turned out, the poor tusker had likely never noticed us and simply veered away into the grass. This incident is a constant reminder to me that while birdwatching is a peaceful pursuit, it is never lacking in thrills.

CHARACTER SKETCH

Character Sketch of Baron Omar Rolf

Baron Omar Rolf

Baron Omar Rolf is a colourful and eccentric character who brings a sense of adventure and humour to Salim Ali’s memoir. An Austrian anthropologist by profession, he is a true nature lover who describes birdwatching as his "second love." When Salim Ali first meets him, the Baron appears as a rugged, barefoot man in crumpled shorts, showing that he is a simple person who is perfectly at home in the wild. His eagerness to wake up early and trek through five-foot-tall grass shows his deep passion for wildlife and his adventurous spirit.

The most memorable trait of the Baron is his incredible physical agility and quick reflexes. Salim Ali describes him as having the "agility of a cat," which is proven when they suddenly

encounter a wild elephant. Without even seeing the animal, the Baron reacts to Salim Ali's signal with amazing speed, sprinting away on his long legs and outdistancing everyone by hundreds of yards. His survival instinct is so sharp that he runs first and asks questions later, leading to the hilarious moment where he stops to ask, "What was it?" This mix of athletic energy and unintentional humour makes him a truly unforgettable character.

Character Sketch:

Dr. Salim Ali

Dr. Salim Ali is the narrator of the story and a world-famous bird expert. He is a man who truly loves his work and finds great joy in nature. Even though he has spent a lifetime exploring dangerous places, he is very humble. He describes birdwatching as a "peaceful" hobby, even though his own stories show that it can be full of excitement and risks. He is very patient and dedicated, often hiding for hours just to watch how birds behave in their natural homes.

Salim Ali is also very brave and has a great sense of humour. When he faces a giant elephant or almost falls off a mountain cliff, he stays calm enough to learn from the experience. He doesn't act like a boring scientist; instead, he tells his stories in a way that makes us laugh, especially when he describes running away from the elephant. He sees birdwatching as a beautiful way to escape the busy world, and his passion for India's birds shines through everything he writes

SPEECH

Nature Club of ABC school Kollam has decided to celebrate 'World Environment Day.' You have been asked to deliver a speech on the importance of birdwatching and the need for nature conservation. Based on your reading of Dr. Salim Ali's "Trills and Thrills," prepare a **speech** for the occasion.

Good morning

Respected teachers and my dear friends,

Today, I want to talk to you about a simple yet wonderful activity: birdwatching, and why we must protect the nature around us.

Birds are some of the most beautiful creatures on Earth. Whether it is the bright colours of a kingfisher or the sweet song of a cuckoo, birds bring a sense of peace to our busy lives. As the famous "Birdman of India," Dr. Salim Ali, once said, birdwatching is not just a hobby; it is an adventure that helps us feel connected to the world.

But birds are more than just pretty to look at. They are like "nature's messengers." When birds start to disappear from an area, it is a warning sign that the environment is in trouble—perhaps because of pollution, or because too many trees are being cut down. By watching birds, we learn to notice these changes before it is too late.

DE KOLAM

Unfortunately, birds today are losing their homes. When we destroy forests and use harmful chemicals, we make it hard for them to survive. If birds disappear, the balance of nature will be broken.

The good news is that we can help! You don’t need to do anything big to make a difference. You can: Plant a tree in your garden. Keep a bowl of clean water for birds during the hot summer. Avoid using plastic and keep your surroundings clean. Simply stop and listen to their songs to appreciate their beauty.

In conclusion, birdwatching teaches us to be kind and patient. By protecting birds, we are actually protecting our own future and our beautiful planet. Let us all promised to be friends of nature starting today.

Thank you and have a wonderful day

LETTER

In the lesson "Trills and Thrills," Baron Omar Rolf accompanies Dr. Salim Ali on a birdwatching expedition in Parambikulam. During the trek, they have a narrow escape from a wild tusker. Imagine you are Baron Omar Rolf. Write a **letter** to your friend in Austria describing the exciting encounter with the elephant and your experience of birdwatching with the 'Birdman of India'.

Forest Bungalow,

Room No:5

Parambikulam.

Forest Camp

Date

My dear Allen,

I hope you are doing well back in Austria. I am writing to you from a beautiful forest in South India. I have just had the most incredible adventure with the famous "Birdman of India," Dr. Salim Ali.

We met at a forest bungalow, and he was kind enough to take me along for a morning of birdwatching. The jungle here is thick and wild, with grass so tall it grows over my head! We were searching for a rare little bird called the Grass Warbler.

Suddenly, things got very exciting. As we turned a corner, we found ourselves face-to-face with a massive wild elephant! Salim Ali signalled me to run, and I didn't wait a second. I ran so fast and so far that I didn't even stop to look back. Salim Ali told me later that I moved with the "agility of a cat!" It was a bit embarrassing because I didn't even see the elephant—I just saw Salim running and decided to outrun him!

DE KOLAM

Thankfully, the elephant was peaceful and wandered away. This trip has been a wonderful experience, and Dr. Ali is a brilliant guide. I learned that birdwatching in India is definitely not a boring hobby!

I look forward to seeing you soon and telling you more.

Yours affectionately,

Omar Rolf

Signature